

PLANNING YOUR PLOT

If you have the luxury of a large backyard or urban garden, make the most of it by ensuring that you plan your plot carefully. Bear in mind that some crops require differing soil types, locations, and microclimates, and that some will spread and become quite large (see individual growing guides for details). Keep a record of what you grow year to year and consider rotating crops to get the best from your soil and ensure high yields.

DESIGN YOUR LAYOUT

Sketch out the dimensions and boundaries of your plot and decide which crops you want to grow. Start by inserting the features that will be permanent, such as compost bins, sheds, paths, and fruit trees. Think next about the microclimates that exist in your garden, such as frost pockets where plants are less likely to thrive, or a south-facing wall that could act as a shelter for cordons of delicate fruit. When planning your plot, make sure that you create an environment that will be easy for you to work in.

Leave pathways between rows so that you can reach crops easily for watering and weeding. Make beds an accessible size to avoid damaging surrounding plants; the ideal width is about 4 ft (1.2 m).

PLANT YOUR CROPS

Some crops require specific planting formations; corn, for example, is best planted in a fairly dense grid formation to increase its chances of pollination, while crops such as potatoes are traditionally grown in rows—consider which crops you want to grow and how their specific needs might affect your planning. Think also about the way that light hits your plot during the day—you don't want to cast small crops such as lettuce into shadow if they become stranded behind a tall crop such as runner beans.

INTEGRATE YOUR GARDEN

Even if you have a smaller space, there is a design to suit, whatever your taste—from formal kitchen garden layouts to more flexible cottage garden or mixed planting systems. If you are growing crops in your backyard